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AT FORT ROACH I had my first exposure to the peculiar ways of the federal bureaucracy since those days during the Depression when Jack worked on Dixon's relief program. About midway through the war, Congress challenged the military's widespread use of civilian workers, saying it was a drain on the defense industry and the nation's pool of draft-age men. An order went out setting a goal for reducing civilian employees at every post where they were used. It didn't affect us. Although we'd asked for civilian typists to help our writers with their scripts, we were refused because our work was regarded as too secret to employ civilians; often, we learned the identity of the targets planned for future bombing missions long before they occurred, so enormous security precautions had to be imposed at the post. But one day I was visited by two men from Washington. They told me they were checking out our need for civilians. I told them we couldn't have any. They smiled at each other and said, "You'll have 'em."

Sure enough, one day a contingent of fifty civilians arrived and announced they were going to establish a personnel office for the two hundred or so civilian employees that were going to be sent to us.

At the time, we had about twelve hundred military men at the base, and our whole personnel section consisted of eighteen people.

When the new civilian employees began arriving, every one of them was a transfer from another military installation; there'd been a program to reduce the number of civilians assigned to the military; instead, the military ended up with more civilian employees than they'd had